GRACE TABERNACLE COMMUNITY CHURCH

220 Maple Avenue, Hartford, CT 06114
(860) 555-0189

CHRISTMAS PROGRAM 2026

"LIGHT HAS COME"

Wednesday, December 16, 2026 | 7:00 PM
Main Sanctuary

Scripture Anchor: John 1:5 -- "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it."

Education Committee Chair: Shanice R. Giles
Senior Pastor: Pastor James Mitchell
Program Director: Shanice R. Giles
Music Director: Denise Watkins

ORDER OF SERVICE

7:00 PM -- Prelude Music
Instrumental selection: "O Come All Ye Faithful" (piano and violin)
Performers: Sister Claudette Brown (piano) and Brother Marcus Thompson (violin)
Note to musicians: Begin prelude no later than 6:55 PM. Repeat as needed until the sanctuary is fully seated.

7:07 PM -- Welcome and Call to Worship
Pastor James Mitchell opens the service.
Congregation reading (responsive): printed in program
Leader: In the beginning was the Word.
Congregation: And the Word was with God.
Leader: And the Word was God.
Congregation: And the light shines in the darkness.
All: And the darkness has not overcome it.

7:12 PM -- Children's Choir -- "Away in a Manger" (traditional arrangement)
Ages 4 to 7, Room 4 class. Directed by Brenda Okafor.
Children process from the back wearing white robes with gold sashes.
Note: Children exit to the side door after their number and return to their families in the pew. Brenda will have a parent aide at the side door to escort children.

7:18 PM -- Scripture Reading
Reader: LaShonda Reeves
Text: Luke 2:1-7 (NIV)
Note: Read slowly and clearly. No microphone adjustment needed; LaShonda was tested at the October rehearsal.

7:22 PM -- Upper Elementary Dramatic Presentation -- "The Innkeeper's Wife"
A short original monologue from the perspective of the innkeeper's wife on the night of the nativity.
Performed by: Jordan Ellis, age 11 (grades 3 to 5 class)
Director: Terrence Moore
Length: approximately 6 minutes
Prop note: One lantern (battery, not open flame) on the stage left table. Terrence will place it before the service.

7:28 PM -- Scripture Reading
Reader: Yvette Ellis
Text: Luke 2:8-14 (NIV) -- the shepherds and the angel

7:32 PM -- Congregational Carol -- "Hark the Herald Angels Sing"
All verses. Congregation stands. Denise Watkins leads from the piano. Words printed in program.

7:37 PM -- Children's Presentation -- Upper Group (grades 3 to 5)
"The Gifts of Light" -- a series of 12 short spoken parts, each child naming one gift of light.
Director: Terrence Moore. Children stand at the front in a single line.
Gifts named: Faith, Hope, Love, Joy, Peace, Patience, Kindness, Goodness, Courage, Purpose, Family, Grace.
Note: Each child should speak clearly and slowly. Terrence will cue each child with a nod.

7:47 PM -- Adult Choir -- "O Holy Night"
Soloist: Sister Darlene Watkins (Denise's sister-in-law; has been briefed and is confirmed)
Full choir for final chorus. Choir processes from side door during the introduction.

7:55 PM -- Message from Pastor Mitchell
Title: "The Light That Does Not Fail"
Estimated length: 12 to 15 minutes.
Note: Pastor Mitchell has reviewed the program flow and is aware of the 8:15 PM target close.

8:10 PM -- Lighting of the Candles
Ushers distribute battery-operated candles (in the storage cabinet, already packaged by pew).
Joyce Freeman coordinates candle distribution; she will have two helpers at the rear of the sanctuary.
Congregation holds candles up as Denise Watkins plays "Silent Night" (instrumental, softly).
No spoken words during this portion. Let the moment breathe.
Candles are collected by ushers as the recessional begins.

8:17 PM -- Closing Prayer
Pastor James Mitchell

8:20 PM -- Recessional
All performers and the choir process out as the congregation sings "Go Tell It on the Mountain."
Denise Watkins leads from the piano. Words printed in program.

8:25 PM (approx) -- Fellowship
Reception in the Fellowship Hall immediately following. Refreshments coordinated by the hospitality committee.
Cookies, punch, coffee, and sparkling cider.
Note to committee members: Do not start moving chairs until the sanctuary is at least 80% empty.

VOLUNTEER ROLES AND POSITIONS

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Role  |  Volunteer  |  Notes
Program Coordinator  |  Shanice R. Giles  |  Overall lead; backstage coor
Music Director  |  Denise Watkins  |  Piano and choir; responsible
Children's Choir Director (a  |  Brenda Okafor  |  Processional cue at 7:12 PM;
Upper Elementary Director  |  Terrence Moore  |  Dramatic presentation and gr
Candle Distribution Lead  |  Joyce Freeman  |  Two helpers TBD; brief befor
Ushers (4)  |  Sandra Pittman, Darnell Coop  |  Seating, programs, candle co
Sound and A/V  |  Darnell Cooper  |  Arrive by 5:30 PM; test all
Program Printing  |  Rose Delaney (church admin o  |  Print 120 copies; done by De
Soloist Liaison  |  Shanice R. Giles  |  Confirm with Sister Darlene
Reception Setup  |  Hospitality Committee  |  Fellowship Hall setup by 6:3
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REHEARSAL SCHEDULE

Sunday, November 8, 2026 -- 12:45 to 2:00 PM -- All children; choir; individual speaker run-through
Sunday, November 22, 2026 -- 12:45 to 2:00 PM -- Full program; all parts; first full walk-through
Sunday, December 6, 2026 -- 12:45 to 2:00 PM -- Full program with sound and A/V
Sunday, December 13, 2026 -- 12:45 to 2:00 PM -- Final dress rehearsal; costumes; full run

NOTES FOR SHANICE

Family note: Marcus has a speaking part in the "Gifts of Light" segment -- he will say "Family." He is excited and has been practicing.
Church dinner potluck: December 20 -- bring pot roast.
Mary Claire is doing the cake for the December 4 birthday dinner this Sunday, so nothing to bring this week. Just show up.
The solo by Sister Darlene is confirmed. She is singing it in the key of B-flat. Denise has the chart.